



LITTLE ROOTS FOREST SCHOOL

Family Handbook

Wednesdays • 9:30 to 11:00 AM

McCollum Park • Everett, WA

Ages 1 to 3 with a parent or caregiver

Founded by Mattison Williams • Est. 2026

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Welcome to Little Roots!

Little Roots started the way most good things do. With a mom who couldn't find what she was looking for.

I'm Mattison. While earning my bachelor's in elementary education at Western Washington University, I taught preschool at A Little Darling School in Bellingham, WA, working alongside my mentor Netta Darling. That's where my love of early childhood first took root, and where I learned her simple but powerful teaching philosophy: the environment is the teacher. Let children lead. Trust the process.

Then I spent years as a middle school science teacher, watching kids light up when they got to touch, build, and explore instead of just sitting and listening. But when I became a mom, everything shifted. I watched my daughter reach for leaves and study bugs before she could walk, completely absorbed in the world around her. And I kept thinking, where is the space built for this? Netta's words stayed with me, and they gave me the courage to build something of my own.

Little Roots Forest School is the class I wished existed when I was a new mom looking for connection, purpose, and a reason to get outside on a Wednesday morning. It's nature-based, child-led, and built for the whole family, not just the little ones. Little Roots is intentionally small. We cap our class at 15 families so every child gets the space, attention, and unhurried time they deserve.

This handbook has everything you need to feel ready. Give it a read before our first session, and reach out if you have any questions.

See you in the forest.

Mattison Williams

Founder and Lead Teacher, Little Roots Forest School

Meet Your Teachers



Mattison Williams, Founder and Lead Teacher

Licensed Washington State educator. Former preschool and middle school science teacher (NGSS). Bachelor's in Elementary Education with a focus in general sciences from Western Washington University. Trained alongside Netta Darling at A Little Darling School in Bellingham, whose philosophy of child-led learning shaped everything about Little Roots. Pediatric CPR & First Aid certified. Mom to one nature-loving girl who'll be right there with your little ones every Wednesday.



Katelyn, Co-Teacher

Early childhood education student and YMCA youth program leader. At the YMCA she is a coach, referee, and summer camp leader. Pediatric CPR & First Aid certified. Mattison's cousin and the calm, steady presence your little ones will love having in the forest every Wednesday.

What We Believe

The forest is the classroom. Toddlers learn best from real things they can touch, smell, and splash in. So we skip the worksheets and let the forest do the teaching. Sticks become counting tools, puddles become science labs, and a fallen log becomes a balance beam.

Kids lead, we follow. If your toddler wants to explore the same plant for fifteen minutes, we let them. Through that deep focus they are learning and making sense of their world. We're not here to rush anyone through a checklist.

Everyone teaches, everyone learns. You're not here to watch from a bench. You're part of the class. At Little Roots, grown-ups learn alongside their children, noticing what they notice and wondering what they wonder. By week three, you'll catch yourself saying "I notice..." and "I wonder..." at the grocery store. That's the goal.

Everything has a purpose. When your toddler dumps a cup of water for the 47th time, they're not being difficult. They're studying gravity and cause and effect. When they sort rocks into a muffin tin, that's early math. We'll help you see the learning that's already happening in their play.

This is for you, too. Parenting little ones can feel isolating, especially in the PNW rain. Little Roots is a community, a place where you can connect with other families who care about the same things you do. You'll leave each session with ideas, confidence, and maybe a friend who also doesn't mind their kid eating a little dirt.

Our Approach

Little Roots is inspired by the forest school tradition, but we don't follow a single method. We blend four educational philosophies, Reggio Emilia, Montessori, Waldorf, and Charlotte Mason, into something built for toddlers ages 1 to 3, for the Pacific Northwest forest, and for the families who come each week.

When most people hear “forest school,” they picture older kids building shelters and whittling sticks. Ours looks different because our learners are still figuring out what happens when they step in a puddle on purpose. We meet them where they are.

Underneath all four philosophies is the same idea. The environment is the teacher, children lead, and we trust the process.

From Reggio Emilia: The Environment as Teacher

This is our biggest influence. We plan every week, but we plan from what we saw the week before. When the kids couldn't stop sending things rolling and splatting, we built a whole morning around it. When they kept going back to scooping, we added more rice and dry pouring stations. The children show us what they're ready for by what they reach for.

From Montessori: Independence and Real Work

We set things up so kids can do real work themselves, at their own pace. Nobody rushes them and nobody does it for them.

We also borrow a lot of how we talk to children from Montessori. We see toddlers as capable learners, so we get down to their level, offer simple choices, and describe what we see instead of saying “good job,” like “You carried that whole bucket by yourself.” We tell them what to do instead of what not to do, and we give them time to try before we step in.

From Waldorf: Rhythm and Wonder

Every Wednesday follows the same rhythm: arrival, opening circle, stations, snack, morning gathering, nature walk, and closing circle. Some things are out every single week, like the book and instrument blanket, the pebblestones, and a water painting spot on a fallen log. Toddlers settle when they know what comes next. We lean on songs, stories, and real materials instead of flashcards or worksheets.

From Charlotte Mason: Nature as the First Teacher

Charlotte Mason believed young children learn best from real things, like watching a real bird or standing in the rain. Our nature walks are where this lives. Each week we ask one guiding question at the start, like “What is falling?” or “Who lives under here?” and then we let it sit. We go slow, pass out hand lenses, and say out loud what we notice. “I notice that mushroom is growing on the log. I wonder why.” That small habit builds observation,

language, and care for the natural world. Our walks quietly build the same big ideas scientists use, like noticing patterns and how things change over time.

At the Stations

Each week we set up six to eight stations, and children move freely between them. Nobody tells them where to go or when to switch. Here's what you'll usually find:

Collaborative Art. The whole class builds one big canvas together over the season. Each week adds a new layer with a new tool. We've used foam rollers, apple halves, bug stamps, fly swatters, and pressed leaves. This canvas becomes the crowns at our Crown Celebration.

Individual Art. This is your child's take-home art, and it's always process art, so there's never a model to copy. Butterfly prints on folded plates, salad spinner paintings, crayon under watercolor, nature frames the kids carry on the walk. Your child decides what it becomes. Dry art from past weeks hangs on our art line so you can grab it on your way out.

Sensory Play. Mud, water, rice, oats, oobleck, clay, and whatever the forest drops that week. Sensory play helps toddlers make sense of their world and settle their bodies. If your child wants to squish mud between their fingers for twenty minutes, let them. That's the work.

Mud Kitchen. The mud kitchen is out almost every week, and the base changes with the theme. We've made herb mud with rosemary and mint, fizzing mud, bubble soup, oat pies, and leaf soup with cinnamon sticks. Kids stir, pour, scoop, and serve, and a lot of language happens over a pot of mud.

Playdough. Out almost every week in a color that fits the theme. Kids press in twigs and pebbles, walk plastic bugs across it to leave tracks, and roll it out with stamp rollers.

Nature Exploration. Hand lenses, collection cups, and small world trays with real moss, bark, and pinecones. We look closely at whatever the forest gives us that day, like a feather, a slug, or a patch of moss. The curriculum changes with the seasons because the forest does.

Motor Skills. Pebblestones and milk crates for climbing and balancing, plus logs, roots, and uneven ground on the trail. This is age-appropriate risk, and it builds confidence and body awareness.

Practical Life. Real jobs for little hands. Picking pom pom apples off a line and sorting them into bowls, running a toy car wash, scrubbing muddy animals clean, tapping golf tees into a

squash, and moving pinecones with tongs. Toddlers are extremely capable, and they light up when they get to show you.

Water Painting. Out every single week on a fallen log. Kids paint with plain water on a magic water canvas, and their marks show up dark, then slowly fade as it dries, so they can paint again and again.

Book and Instrument Blanket. A quiet spot that's out every week with books and instruments. Some kids need a break from the busy stations, and some just want to read.

We also bring a pop-up privacy tent with a changing mat and children's potty, so diaper changes, toileting, and clothes changes are covered rain or shine.

What Is Process Art?

Process art means the focus is on making, not on a finished product that looks a certain way. There's no model to copy, no right way to do it, and no adult hovering to make sure the tree looks like a tree. Your child might paint with a pinecone, smear mud across paper, or tear and layer leaves into a collage. Every choice is theirs.

It builds fine motor skills, hand-eye coordination, decision-making, and creative confidence. Most of all, it teaches your child that their ideas have value, even when they don't match anyone else's.

A note for parents: You might see your child's art and think "that's just a smear of brown paint." To your child, it's the mud they discovered on the trail, the color of the bark they touched, the feeling of the brush in their hand for the first time. That's not "just" anything. That's a whole world of learning on a single piece of paper.

What They're Really Learning

Parents sometimes wonder what a two-year-old is getting from all this. A lot, actually.

Scooping mud into a cup is fine motor work. Balancing on a pebblestone is gross motor and spatial awareness. Sitting in circle for a story builds language and connection. Choosing which station to visit next is early decision-making, and watching a friend try something and then trying it too is how toddlers learn from each other. When they come back to the same station week after week and do something new, that's persistence.

None of this needs a worksheet. It needs the right setting, a steady rhythm, and grown-ups who know what to look for. That's what we're here for.

The Crown Celebration

This is one of our favorite Little Roots traditions.

All season, the class builds one big canvas together, one layer at a time. On the last morning of the season, we cut it into crowns, one for every child. We go around the circle and each child picks their own crown. Then we head out on the trail together.

We also keep a handprint canvas with the season's name on it. Every child adds a hand, and it comes back out at every celebration.

Each crown holds a little of every week and every hand that painted it. Your child walks out of the forest wearing something the whole class made together, and that's a pretty magical thing.

Upcoming Crown Celebrations: Wednesday, November 18, 2026. Wednesday, February 24, 2027. Wednesday, May 26, 2027. Wednesday, August 25, 2027.

What a Session Looks Like

Every Wednesday follows the same rhythm, not a rigid schedule. We do this on purpose, because toddlers feel safe when they know what's coming. The activities change each week, but the flow stays the same. Times are approximate. We follow a rhythm, not a clock.

Time	What Happens
9:30	Arrival and Free Explore: Stations are already set up when you walk in. Your child can start exploring right away while everyone settles in.
9:45	Opening Circle: A short five minutes together. We ring the chime, sing our name song so every child hears their name, and take a quick look at the day. There's also a question of the day for the grown-ups. Then it's right back to the stations.
9:50	Discovery Stations: Six to eight stations, like the mud kitchen, playdough, sensory bins, art, and small world trays. Your child moves freely between them. They lead, and we follow.
10:20	Snack Time: Bring a nut-free snack from home. We keep a handwashing station with soap and offer hand sanitizer, so you can clean hands before snack.
10:30	Morning Gathering: We sing Open, Shut Them, then settle in for a short, rhythmic story picked around the day's nature focus. We say good morning to Pip, our class chickadee finger puppet, then a movement song or two to shake out the wiggles.
10:45	Nature Walk: We head out on the forest loop at toddler pace, with a guiding question like "What is falling?" We walk the same trail every week on purpose, so kids start to notice what is different. The children lead the way.
10:55	Closing Circle: We circle up right on the trail, sing The More We Get Together with ASL signs, and say goodbye to the forest together. Families are welcome to stay and play at the park!

Your Role During the Session: You're your child's guide. Stay near them, follow their lead, and enjoy the experience with them. We'll model language and developmental narration throughout the session so you can use it at home too.

Holiday Break: We meet every Wednesday, all year round. Our only break is for winter, with no class on December 23 and December 30.

A Quick Note on Snack Time: Snack time is simple and low-key. Families sit together on picnic or outdoor blankets, so please bring one to sit on. Eating right into circle is totally fine. A snacking toddler is often a happy, settled one.

Each family brings their own nut-free snack, and we don't share food between families to keep allergy-sensitive kids safe.

Our Forest Promise

These are the shared agreements that make Little Roots work for everyone. Think of them less like rules and more like how we take care of each other out here.

For the grown-ups:

- Stay close to your child, within eyesight and earshot at all times. You're their person out here.
- Put your phone away during the session. I know it's hard. But these moments are so short, and your kid notices when you're present.
- Be kind to all the kids, not just yours. It takes a village, and this is ours.
- Show up on time. Late arrivals interrupt circle time and throw off the rhythm for everyone.
- Dress for a mess. Seriously. Both of you. If you're worried about the outfit, it's the wrong outfit.
- Let your kid take risks. I know it's scary. We'll talk more about this. But that log they want to climb on? Let them try. You are right there to support them.

For the little ones (with your help):

- Gentle hands with friends, animals, and plants.
- We look at creatures and let them go. The forest is their home.
- We leave the forest as beautiful as we found it.
- Sticks stay low, below our shoulders.
- When we hear the chime, it's time to come together.

How We Handle Big Feelings

Toddlers have big emotions. That's not a problem. That's development. At Little Roots, we don't do time-outs, we don't shame, and we don't force anyone to do anything. Here's what we do instead:

- We describe what we see: "You're holding that stick up high" instead of "Stop!"
- We offer choices: "You can dig here or splash over there. Which one?"
- We name the feeling: "You're frustrated because the rock won't balance. That makes sense."
- We redirect gently: "Sand stays low. Let's pour it into the bucket instead."
- We trust you to know your kid. If they need a break, a walk, a snack, or just a really long hug, take it. Zero judgment.

Here's what this looks like in action: Your toddler is at the mud kitchen, happily stirring a bowl of dirt soup. Another child reaches over and grabs the spoon right out of their hand. Your child's face crumbles and they start to cry.

Instead of jumping in with "That's okay!" or "Share, please!" we try something different. We get down low and describe what happened: "You were using that spoon and someone took it. That's frustrating." We let the feeling land. Then we offer a choice: "Would you like to ask for it back, or would you like to use this other spoon?" Meanwhile, we gently narrate for the other child too: "You wanted a turn with the spoon. Your friend was still using it. Let's find you one."

No shaming. Not forcing a hug or a "sorry." Both kids get their feelings seen, and both kids learn something real about how relationships work. It's not always tidy, and that's the point.

A note on big feelings: They're going to happen. A toddler crying in the forest is still a toddler having a wonderful childhood. Step away if you need to. Take a breath. We've all been there and we've got your back.

How We Talk to Kids

At Little Roots, we use a framework called Nonviolent Communication (NVC), developed by Marshall Rosenberg, that centers on empathy, observation, and authentic expression. You might hear us use language like “I notice you feel frustrated because you wanted a turn with the shovel” rather than “Stop grabbing” or “Be nice.”

NVC focuses on four simple steps: observing without judgment, naming feelings, identifying needs, and making requests. Even with our youngest learners, we practice this by narrating what we see, validating big emotions, and modeling respectful language throughout our time together.

This looks like:

- “I see you’re upset. You wanted more time at the water station.”
- “I see you both want the same stick. What can we do?”
- “You’re feeling excited! You found something new on the trail.”

We encourage families to explore NVC at home too. When children hear their feelings and needs reflected back to them from an early age, they build the foundation for empathy, self-awareness, and healthy communication that lasts a lifetime.

Why We Let Kids Take Risks

Research consistently shows that age-appropriate risk (climbing a low log, walking on uneven ground, touching something unfamiliar) builds confidence, resilience, spatial awareness, and self-regulation. Kids who are allowed to assess risk for themselves become safer and more capable, not less.

At Little Roots, risky play might look like:

- Climbing on a low stump or fallen log
- Walking on uneven, rooty, muddy ground
- Picking up sticks, rocks, and pinecones
- Splashing in shallow puddles
- Getting genuinely, gloriously muddy
- Touching moss, bark, wet leaves, and other textures

What we ask of you: Try swapping “be careful!” for something more specific. Instead of creating fear, build awareness:

- “Do you feel steady on that log?”
- “Notice that branch. It’s a little wobbly.”
- “Where are you going to put your foot next?”

These small shifts help your child develop body awareness instead of anxiety. And trust me, as a former science teacher and a mom, I would never put your child in a situation where the risk of serious injury is high. We’re talking about mud and stumps, not cliff edges.

We will never force a child into a risky situation. Every kid moves at their own speed, and being cautious is respected just as much as being adventurous.

What to Bring

A small backpack for your child's gear. Older toddlers might love carrying their own (we recommend 12L with a chest clip if they do), but for younger ones, you'll probably just carry it yourself or toss everything in your own bag. Either way works great. Label everything with your child's name. You'd be amazed how many identical water bottles show up.

In the Backpack (Every Week)

- Reusable water bottle (full!)
- Snack in a sealed container (nut-free please)
- Full change of clothes (shirt, pants, socks, and underwear for the weather)
- Diapers, wipes, and bags if your child is still in diapers
- Two clean washcloths in a ziplock bag (for muddy hands and faces)
- Sunscreen and bug spray (apply before arrival, and bring them along if you want to reapply)
- A picnic or outdoor blanket to sit on at snack

Optional but Nice to Have

- A blanket with a waterproof backing for wet mornings

What to Wear

This is the Pacific Northwest. It will rain. It will be muddy. Your child will find the one puddle you didn't see coming. Dress for it, and this goes for you too. Our Recommended Gear page (littleroots.school/recommended) has everything we recommend, plus these discounts for Little Roots families:

- OAKI: Use code LITTLEROOTS for 25% off orders over \$29.99, plus free shipping over \$100.
- iksplor: Use code LITTLEROOTS for 20% off.
- hope&plum: 10% off baby carriers through our referral link on the Recommended Gear page.

Weather	What to Wear
Rainy	Rain jacket and rain pants, or a one-piece rain suit, for both of you. Waterproof boots. Pull rain pants OVER the boots (trust me on this one). Pack a dry change of clothes.
Cold or Snow	Layers! A warm base layer in wool or synthetic (avoid cotton, it holds moisture), a fleece or wool mid-layer, and a waterproof outer shell. Warm hat, mittens, wool socks. On snowy days, swap rain boots for insulated snow boots and add snow pants over the base layers.
Warm	Lightweight long sleeves and pants protect from scratches and sun. Closed-toe shoes always. Sun hat. Sunscreen before arrival.
Every Day	Closed-toe shoes with good grip. No sandals, no Crocs, no flip-flops on the trail. Clothes that can get dirty. A mindset that mud washes out.

Pro tip: Keep a “forest school bin” in your car with rain gear, backup boots, and a change of clothes. You'll never get caught off guard by PNW weather again.

Toileting & Changing

Toddlers are in all different places with toileting, and we support whatever works for your family: diapers, pull-ups, underwear, elimination communication, or anywhere in between. There's no judgment here. We've seen it all, and every approach is welcome at Little Roots.

The Changing Tent

We bring a pop-up privacy tent to every class. Inside you'll find:

- A children's potty for toddlers who are learning or practicing
- A changing mat for diaper changes
- Wipes and hand sanitizer
- Diaper disposal bags

The tent is yours to use anytime during the session. You're responsible for changing and toileting your own child. We're happy to point you to the tent or hold your coffee while you handle it, but we won't change diapers or assist with toileting directly.

Getting Wet & Messy

It's going to happen. Between a mud kitchen, water play, sensory stations, and just being a toddler in the forest, your child will almost certainly need a clothing change at some point. The changing tent doubles as a private space to swap into dry clothes. This is why we ask you to bring a full change of weather-appropriate clothes in your child's backpack every single week.

A note on elimination communication: If your family practices EC, that's wonderful. Let us know so we can support you, whether that means being mindful of timing, having the potty easily accessible, or just understanding your signals. We think it's great that you're tuned in to your child's cues.

When to Stay Home

- Fever of 100.4°F or higher (or within 24 hours of it breaking without meds)
- Vomiting or diarrhea within the last 24 hours
- An undiagnosed rash
- Persistent cough, thick or green nasal discharge, or trouble breathing

- Pink eye (until cleared by a doctor)
- Any contagious illness (hand-foot-and-mouth, RSV, flu, COVID, strep)
- Head lice

Siblings

Families are messy and complicated and rarely fit into neat age brackets. Here's how we handle siblings:

Younger siblings (under 12 months): Babies in carriers or strollers are always welcome, free with a paid sibling. They're along for the ride, the fresh air, and the sounds of the forest.

Enrolled siblings: Each additional enrolled child is \$49 a month, so two children is \$148 a month total.

Older siblings: Older siblings are welcome to come along on Wednesdays. They can explore the trail, be near their little one, and enjoy the forest with us. The stations, art supplies, and sensory materials are set up per enrolled child, so those stay with the enrolled 1 to 3s. If you'd like an older sibling (around 4 to 5) to join in as a full participant with their own materials, reach out before registering and we'll talk about whether it's a good fit for them and for the group.

Multiples: Absolutely. You may want a second adult to help, but it's not required. We'll be there to support you.

Birthday Celebrations

Birthdays are a big deal when you're little, and we love celebrating them at Little Roots!

If your child's birthday falls close to a session, let us know and we'll celebrate during class. Here's what our forest birthday looks like.

We gather for a Walk Around the Sun, a Montessori tradition. A small sun sits in the center of our circle, and the birthday child walks around it once for each year of their life while we sing together. For a one-year-old, that's one slow loop. For a two-year-old, two. It's a simple way to help little ones feel the passage of time in their body, and it gives the whole class a chance to celebrate this specific child on this specific day.

Then we sing our “Mixing Up a Birthday Cake” song, where we pretend to bake a cake together. We crack the eggs, stir the batter, put it in the oven, and when it’s done, the birthday child gets to blow out the pretend candles while everyone cheers. Then we sing the traditional Happy Birthday.

The birthday child also receives a crown made from our class collaborative art, so it carries a piece of every friend in the class.

Weather & Cancellations

Let me be real with you: we go out in the rain. Rain is some of our best exploring weather. Puddles appear, worms come out, the forest smells incredible, and the sound of rain on the canopy is better than any sound machine. Dress for it and lean in.

We cancel for: Lightning or active thunderstorms, sustained winds over 40 mph, extreme heat (over 95°F), unhealthy air quality for sensitive groups (AQI of 101 or higher), heavy snow or ice that makes roads or trails unsafe, or anything else that isn’t safe. If Everett Public Schools closes for snow or ice, we close too. For cold weather, there’s no set temperature cutoff. We dress in warm layers and use our best judgment on wind chill and conditions.

How you’ll know: If we have to cancel, I’ll let you know as soon as I can by email, and I’ll post it on our Facebook and Instagram stories too. On a late start day, I’ll decide by 7 AM and email you if class is canceled. If thunder rolls in during class, we’ll head out early to stay safe.

Makeup sessions: Any canceled session gets rescheduled or made up at no cost. This doesn’t happen often. Since we started in June 2026, we’ve canceled just once, for poor air quality, and we made it up the following Tuesday.

If your family misses a week: No refunds or makeups for individual absences. Life happens. We’ll miss you and see you next Wednesday.

Health & Safety

- Both instructors hold current Pediatric First Aid and CPR certifications.
- We carry a comprehensive outdoor first aid kit to every session.
- Little Roots School LLC is fully insured with general liability coverage.
- You are responsible for your child at all times. Stay within eyesight and earshot throughout the session.
- All allergies, medical conditions, and emergency contacts must be on your registration form. We keep a printed copy in a waterproof binder at every session.
- If your child has a severe allergy, carry your own EpiPen or medication. Let us know so we can be prepared to help if needed.
- Snacks must be nut-free. Each family brings their own, and we don't share food between families.
- We bring a pop-up changing tent with a children's potty to every session (see Toileting and Changing). For grown-ups, there is a portable toilet about a five minute walk from our spot.

Sunscreen & bug spray: Please apply these to your child before you arrive. We can't apply products to your child, but you're welcome to reapply during class.

If your child gets hurt: Scrapes, bumps, and minor tumbles are a normal part of outdoor play. You are always with your child, and you know them best. Our first aid kit is available to you at every session for cleaning and bandaging minor injuries. If something more serious happens, like a hard fall, a sting, or a potential allergic reaction, we're right there to help you assess and support whatever you decide to do next. In a medical emergency, call 911 first, then your emergency contact.

Cell service and nearest hospital: Cell service at McCollum Park is limited but reliable enough to make phone calls. Data may be spotty depending on your carrier and the trail area. The nearest emergency room is Providence Regional Medical Center Everett (1321 Colby Ave, Everett), about 15 minutes away.

Benefit & Risk Assessment

We believe in being honest with families about what our program involves. Outdoor play with toddlers comes with real benefits and real risks, and we want you to have a clear

picture of both before you join us. The chart below walks through every main activity at Little Roots, what your child gains from it, what could go wrong, and what we do to keep everyone safe.

One thing that shapes everything below: a parent or trusted caregiver stays with their child for the entire session. You are your child's first line of safety out there, and you know them better than anyone. Our role is to create the environment, model the language, and support you. Your role is to stay close, follow their lead, and keep them within eyesight and earshot at all times.

Both teachers hold current Pediatric First Aid and CPR certifications, and we carry a fully stocked outdoor first aid kit to every session.

Sensory Play (Mud, Water, Sand, Natural Textures, Mud Kitchen)

Benefits

Sensory play is how toddlers make sense of the world. Squishing mud, pouring water, running fingers through sand, stirring up pretend soup at the mud kitchen. This kind of hands-on exploration builds fine motor control, supports self-regulation, and helps kids process big feelings. At the mud kitchen in particular, imagination and language start to bloom. Kids name what they are making, invite other children into their play, and practice the early social skills of sharing space and materials. It also develops vocabulary as they describe what they feel (cold, sticky, rough, soft) and builds the neural pathways that later support focus and learning.

Risks

Toddlers put things in their mouths. They can get cold or wet enough to be uncomfortable. Skin irritation is possible from prolonged exposure to mud or water in cold weather. Occasional disputes over tools.

Precautions

All sensory materials are natural and chosen to be toddler-safe (no small objects, beads, or anything that poses a choking hazard). Mud kitchen tools are child-sized, real materials (wooden spoons, metal pots) rather than plastic, with no sharp edges. Parents monitor their own child's mouthing behavior and redirect as needed. Families bring a full change of clothes every week, and the changing tent is available for wet or muddy transitions. On cold days, we keep sensory stations shorter and warmer.

Nature Walks on the Forest Loop

Benefits

Walking on uneven, natural ground is one of the best things a toddler can do for their developing body. It builds balance, core strength, coordination, and spatial awareness in a way no flat playground can. It also teaches observation, patience, and reverence for the natural world as we stop to notice a mushroom, a beetle, or the way light falls through the trees.

Risks

Trips and falls on roots, rocks, or muddy sections. Getting separated from the group if a child wanders. Weather exposure on longer walks.

Precautions

The loop trail we use is well-maintained and appropriate for toddler pace. We walk slowly. Parents stay within arm's reach of their child throughout the walk. We do a head count before we start and check in frequently. On rough weather days, we shorten or skip the walk entirely.

Climbing on Low Stumps and Fallen Logs

Benefits

Age-appropriate climbing is where confidence is built. When a toddler figures out how to get up onto a log by themselves, and then how to get down, they are learning their body can do hard things. Research consistently shows that children who are allowed to take small physical risks become safer, more capable, and more self-aware than children who are protected from them.

Risks

Falls, scrapes, bruises. A child could climb higher than they can safely get down from.

Precautions

We only climb on stumps and logs at a height appropriate for toddlers (generally under knee-height for an adult). Parents stay within arm's reach. We never boost a child up to somewhere they cannot reach on their own. If a child cannot climb up by themselves,

they are not ready for that spot yet. We teach kids to come down feet-first and talk them through where to put their hands and feet.

Stick Play

Benefits

Sticks are one of the best open-ended toys the forest offers. Your toddler will pick them up, carry them, poke at things, and turn them into whatever their imagination decides (a spoon, a magic wand, a fishing pole). Along the way they are building grip strength, hand-eye coordination, and the kind of imaginative play that sets the foundation for language and storytelling.

Risks

Sticks can poke eyes, faces, and other kids. They can break unexpectedly. Kids can trip while carrying them.

Precautions

Our Forest Promise says sticks stay below the shoulders, and we reinforce this gently every session. Big sticks need big spaces, so we help kids move to open areas when they want to carry something long. Parents stay close and redirect before an unsafe situation escalates.

Water Play in Puddles

Benefits

Puddles are a toddler's dream. Splashing, stomping, and pouring water teaches cause and effect, builds gross motor skills, and delivers pure joyful sensory input. It also teaches kids that rain is not something to avoid. It is something to play in.

Risks

Getting genuinely wet and cold. Slipping on wet surfaces. Puddles can contain unexpected debris.

Precautions

We require waterproof boots and rain pants on wet days, and we ask families to pack a full change of clothes every single week. We check puddle areas for glass, sharp objects, or animal waste before kids play. Parents monitor their child's temperature

and comfort and use the changing tent when a swap is needed.

Nature Collecting (Rocks, Leaves, Pinecones, Sticks)

Benefits

Collecting is early math, early science, and early art all rolled into one. Sorting rocks by size, lining up pinecones, comparing leaves. These are the building blocks of classification, counting, and observation. It also teaches kids to slow down and really look, which is a skill most adults have to relearn later.

Risks

Small objects can be a choking hazard for the youngest children. Some natural materials (certain berries, mushrooms, plants) are toxic if eaten.

Precautions

Parents monitor mouthing behavior, especially for the youngest kids in the group. We teach 'we look at it, we don't eat it' as a class rhythm from day one. Teachers point out and name any plants or mushrooms in the area that kids should not touch, and we practice noticing these together over time.

Encounters with Wildlife and Insects

Benefits

Seeing a real slug, a real beetle, a real bird up close teaches kids something no book can. They learn that creatures have their own lives, their own homes, and deserve gentle treatment. These moments build empathy, curiosity, and a lifelong respect for the natural world.

Risks

Bee and wasp stings. Mosquito and tick bites. Occasional larger wildlife (rarely, but McCollum Park is a wooded park).

Precautions

We teach 'we look with our eyes, not our hands' for most creatures. Bugs get observed in collecting jars and released at the end of the session. Parents apply bug spray before arrival if they choose. All known allergies (including bee stings) are noted on registration forms, and families with severe allergies carry their own EpiPen. Teachers

carry a first aid kit at every session.

Encounters with Plants

Benefits

Learning to identify plants, the ones we can touch, the ones we leave alone, the ones that change with the seasons, is one of the oldest forms of education there is. Toddlers absorb this naturally when adults point things out consistently. Over time, they develop a real familiarity with the forest around them.

Risks

Some plants at McCollum Park can cause irritation (stinging nettle), rashes, or illness if eaten (certain berries and mushrooms).

Precautions

Teachers identify and point out any plants of concern at the start of each session. We reinforce 'we look, we don't eat' consistently. Parents stay close to their child during exploration. We do not forage or eat anything from the forest during class, regardless of how safe it may be.

Photos & Privacy

We photograph our sessions for Instagram (@littleroots.school) and to share with enrolled families. Here's our approach:

We never publicly share photos of children's faces. This is a core value at Little Roots, not a preference. On anything public, like Instagram or our website, you'll only see hands, materials, nature finds, tiny boots on the trail, backs of heads, art in progress, and the forest around us. No faces, ever.

On your registration form, you'll choose one of two options:

- Full Permission: your child may be photographed. Photos shared publicly will not show their face.
- No Photography: we'll make every reasonable effort to exclude your child from photos entirely.

Staying Connected

Weekly preview: Every Tuesday morning I'll email families a preview of the week: our nature focus, what to expect, and a weather heads-up so you know how to dress.

Cancellations: By email as soon as I can, plus a post on our Facebook and Instagram stories. On late start days, I'll decide by 7 AM.

Questions: Email me at hello@littleroots.school. I check email Tuesday through Friday and respond within 24 hours. Weekends and Mondays are family time, so messages sent then will get a reply Tuesday morning.

Instagram and Facebook: Follow @littleroots.school on Instagram and Little Roots Forest School on Facebook for activity ideas, nature inspiration, and behind-the-scenes peeks. This is also where I announce openings first.

Bring a Friend!

The best way Little Roots grows is through families like you telling other families about us. Our referral program:

Refer a family who enrolls: \$25 off your next month's tuition.

There's no limit, so the more families you refer, the more you save. Any credits beyond a single month's tuition roll over to the following month. On a term pass? Your credit comes off your next term. Just have your friend mention your name when they register.

Know someone who's curious but not sure? They can book a \$15 trial session and join us for one Wednesday morning. If they love it, the trial counts as their first class. Sometimes seeing it in person is all it takes.

Pricing & Enrollment

Item	Details
Monthly Enrollment	\$99 a month, every month, whether it has four Wednesdays or five. Tuition is priced for the whole year, so the extra Wednesdays in five Wednesday months make up for the two weeks off in December.
Joining Partway	Join anytime! Your first month is prorated based on the Wednesdays left in that month, then it's \$99 a month.
Trial Session	\$15 for one Wednesday morning. If you enroll, it counts as your first class, so you'll just pay for the Wednesdays left that month.
Siblings	\$49 a month for each additional child. Babies under 12 months attend free with a paid sibling.
Winter Term Pass	December 2, 2026 to February 24, 2027. \$229, paid up front (save \$68). Sibling \$109 (save \$38). Winter has no class on December 23 and December 30, which is why it's our lowest priced term.
Spring and Summer Term Passes	Spring: March 3 to May 26, 2027. Summer: June 2 to August 25, 2027. \$269 each (save \$28). Sibling \$129 (save \$18). Passes open before each term starts.
Payment	Payment is processed securely through Stripe. Monthly families get their payment link in the welcome email, and tuition renews automatically. Winter pass families pay on our Register page after submitting the form.
Referral Program	Refer a family who enrolls and get \$25 off your next month's tuition. No limit.

Refund & Cancellation Policy

We're a small business and we plan our supplies, staffing, and session capacity based on enrollment. We've tried to make this policy fair to families while allowing us to operate sustainably.

Monthly Enrollment (\$99 a month)

- Your enrollment is a rolling monthly subscription. Once you're in, you're in!
- You can cancel anytime by email with two weeks' notice before your next billing date.
- No refunds for partial months or missed sessions.

Term Passes

Term passes (\$229 Winter, \$269 other terms) are nonrefundable. There are no refunds for missed sessions or for leaving partway through a term.

If Little Roots cancels a session due to weather or safety, we will reschedule or add a makeup session at no cost.

Before Your First Session

Here's everything you need to do before your first Wednesday:

- Fill out the registration form on our website (littleroots.school/register)
- Pay through Stripe (monthly families get the link in the welcome email, and Winter pass families pay on the Register page)
- Read this handbook (you're almost done!)
- Sign your liability waiver (Jotform sends it in a separate email after you register or book a trial)
- Pack your child's backpack (see What to Bring)
- Check the weather and dress for it (see What to Wear)
- Apply sunscreen and bug spray before you arrive
- Look for your welcome email with parking directions and our exact meeting spot at McCollum Park (it comes within a day or two of registering)

That's it. Show up, breathe the forest air, and let your kid get muddy.

Questions You Probably Have

Is my child too young for forest school?

Not at all! Babies are natural scientists. At 12 months, they're absorbing the world through every sense: feeling bark, hearing birdsong, watching leaves dance. You'll be amazed at what they take in.

My baby is 10 or 11 months. Can we still join?

Probably! The 12-month starting age is a guideline, not a hard cutoff. If your baby is sitting independently and you think they'd enjoy being outdoors with other kids, reach out and we'll chat.

My child is turning 3. Can they keep coming?

Yes! Three year olds are welcome until their fourth birthday.

What if my child won't sit for circle time?

Totally normal and totally fine. Toddlers learn by moving. If your child wants to wander during circle, let them. They're still listening. We keep circles short and engaging for exactly this reason.

What if it rains?

We go! Rain is some of our best exploring weather. Think puddles, worms, dripping leaves, the sound of rain on the canopy. Dress in rain gear and embrace it. We only cancel for safety concerns like lightning, extreme wind, or unhealthy air quality. See Weather and Cancellations for the full list.

Do you meet all year? Are there any breaks?

We meet every Wednesday, all year round. Our only break is for winter, with no class on December 23 and December 30.

Can a grandparent or nanny bring my child?

Absolutely. Any trusted adult caregiver listed on your registration form is welcome. Just make sure they've read this handbook and know the expectations.

Is this a drop-off class?

No. A parent or caregiver stays for the entire session. This is a shared experience. You're learning alongside your kid, not dropping them off. That's what makes it special.

My child has allergies. Is that okay?

We are a nut-free class. Each family brings their own snacks and we don't share food between families. Please note all allergies on your registration form and carry any necessary medications (EpiPen, inhaler, etc.).

What if we have to miss a week?

No worries. We can't offer refunds or makeups for individual absences, but we'll miss you and see you the next week.

How much does it cost?

\$99 a month, every month, whether it has four Wednesdays or five. Your first month is prorated, and term passes are also available. See Pricing and Enrollment for all the details.

How do I register?

Head to littleroots.school/register! Fill out the registration form and you'll get a confirmation right away. Within a day or two, we'll email you a welcome message with the

meeting spot details. Monthly families get their Stripe payment link in that email. Spots are limited to 15 families.

Do I need to re-register each season?

Nope! Monthly enrollment is a rolling subscription, so once you're enrolled, you stay enrolled month to month. If you ever need to cancel, just email us two weeks before your next billing date. Easy as that.

What if spots are full?

Class is limited to 15 families, and spots do fill up. If we're full when you try to register, email us at hello@littleroots.school to be added to our waitlist. We'll reach out as soon as a spot opens.

The forest is waiting. Let's go explore together.

Mattison Williams • Founder and Lead Teacher

[@littleroots.school](mailto:hello@littleroots.school)

hello@littleroots.school